

MARINE MARAUDER

PLATYPTERYGIUS

One of the top marine hunters of its time, the deadly *Platypterygius* cruised the oceans preying on a variety of creatures with its large, conical teeth. It was a type of prehistoric sea-dwelling reptile called an ichthyosaur. While many ichthyosaurs had big flippers, fossils show that *Platypterygius* took this trait to the extreme—its front flippers had evolved to form large paddles that helped it steer through the water with ease. Paleontologists have discovered *Platypterygius* fossils in Cretaceous rocks in many different places, which suggests it may have been spread across several ancient seas.

**MOST
FINGER
BONES**

FISH-SHAPED REPTILE

Although not directly related to modern-day fish, ichthyosaurs such as *Platypterygius* had fishlike proportions and features that helped them survive in their aquatic habitat.

For example, *Platypterygius*'s large tail generated enough thrust to propel its streamlined body through the water.

Scientists think that *Platypterygius* may have had a blubberlike layer of fat that kept it warm, like modern-day whales and leatherback turtles.

A ring of bone supported *Platypterygius*'s eyeball.

Modified hands

Attached to a small, bulky arm, *Platypterygius*'s large front flippers were modified hands, with about seven to nine fingers each. These fingers contained a large number of tiny bones that made the flippers rigid, allowing the creature to navigate efficiently through the water and keep itself afloat.

